

TIOBE Index March 2026:

How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Audience: Software Engineering Leads & Technology Strategists

METHODOLOGY

The TIOBE Programming Community Index has tracked language popularity monthly since 2001. Ratings measure how much a language is discussed online — not lines of code written or language quality.

Data sources: Google • Bing • Wikipedia • Amazon • 20+ additional search engines & sites

March 2026 methodology note: LLM-based assessment was considered and rejected — LLMs are trained on the same web pages search engines index, so the methodology remains anchored to direct web-page volume.

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

TIOBE Top 20 Programming Languages — March 2026

Rank '26	Rank '25	Language	Rating	YoY Δ
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

KEY HIGHLIGHTS

► Python #1 — 21.25%

Leads by a massive margin but posted the largest YoY decline among top 5: -2.59 pp

► C surges to #2 — +2.02 pp

Climbed from 4th to 2nd; largest gain in the top 5

► Top 4 = 48.97% of index

Python + C + C++ + Java together hold nearly half the entire index

► C# steady at #5 — +1.49 pp

Won Language of the Year 2023 & 2025; continued .NET ecosystem growth

► Go drops #7 → #16 — -1.49 pp

Sharpest decline of any top-20 language

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Year-over-year rank changes — March 2025 → March 2026

▲ GAINERS

Perl Entrenched in legacy infra & scientific pipelines	#24 → #11 +13 spots	+1.05%
R Data-science demand sustaining strong growth	#16 → #9 +7 spots	+0.94%
Swift Apple platform growth; re-enters top 20	#26 → #20 +6 spots	+0.44%
C Largest rating gain in the top 5	#4 → #2 +2 spots	+2.02%
C# 2023 & 2025 Language of the Year	#5 → #5 Steady	+1.49%
Assembly Systems & embedded programming resilience	#17 → #17 Steady	+0.42%

▼ LOSERS

Go Sharpest drop in top 20; possibly displaced by Rust	#7 → #16 -9 spots	-1.49%
C++ Largest rating loss in top 5	#2 → #3 -1 spot	-2.90%
Java Continued long-term decline since 2018 peak	#3 → #4 -1 spot	-2.37%
PHP Steady erosion vs. modern web frameworks	#13 → #18 -5 spots	-0.25%
Fortran Slipped despite niche scientific community	#11 → #13 -2 spots	-0.25%
SQL Slight decline despite ubiquitous use	#8 → #8 Steady	-0.57%

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Long-term rank snapshots (1986–2026) and 24-year popularity trend highlights

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—
Go	16	11	60	16	—	—	—	—
Ada	19	36	25	22	16	18	6	10
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4

Rank color guide: #1-3 #4-10 #11-20 #21+

24-YEAR TREND HIGHLIGHTS

► Python's Meteoric Rise

Unranked before 1991. Entered top 30 by 2001.
Surged to #1 after 2018. Peaked >25%, now 21.25%.

► C — The Perennial #1

Only language in top 2 across all nine decades
of measurement (1986–2026). Current resurgence.

► Java's Peak and Decline

Dominated 2005–2018 at 25%+. Now under 8%.
Dropped from #1 in 2016 to #4 today.

► JavaScript's Ceiling

Never exceeded ~5% on TIOBE despite web
dominance. Currently 3.45% — stable plateau.

► Lisp → Python Reversal

Lisp was #2 in 1986; now #26. Python didn't
exist in 1986; now leads the entire index.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language

TIOBE 'Language of the Year' Award — Largest single-year rating gain

2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016
★	★	★	★	★	★	★	★	—	★
C#	Python	C#	C++	Python	Python	C	Python	—	Go
2nd consecutive win; .NET ecosystem growth	6th total win — unprecedented	First win; .NET renaissance	Resurgence in systems & game dev	5th win; ML/AI boom continues	4th win; pandemic-era data science surge	Embedded systems & IoT boom	3rd win; deep learning drives adoption	Data not available in source	Microservices era peak; precedes current decline

6x

Python total wins (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024)

2x

C# back-to-back 2023 & 2025

2016

Go's only win — precedes 9-spot drop

Award = largest rating gain in calendar year, not cumulative rank

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Key findings & actionable implications for hiring, training, and tooling decisions

Python: Dominant but Decelerating

At 21.25% Python leads by a wide margin — but its -2.59 pp YoY drop is the largest in the top 5. Watch whether this signals market saturation or diversification away from Python-heavy AI stacks.

C's Resurgence Demands Attention

C gained +2.02 pp and climbed to #2. With embedded systems, IoT, and performance-critical infrastructure booming, C expertise may be undervalued in current hiring pipelines.

C# Is Winning Hearts — Twice

Back-to-back 'Language of the Year' (2023 & 2025). The .NET ecosystem is growing. If your stack involves Microsoft platforms, C# investment has clear industry momentum.

Go's Sharp Fall Is a Hiring Signal

Dropping from 7th to 16th (-1.49 pp) is the steepest decline in the top 20. Rust (#14, +0.09 pp) may be displacing Go in systems programming. Re-evaluate Go-heavy roadmaps.

Legacy Languages Are Alive — Plan Accordingly

Perl jumped to 11th; Fortran remains top 15; R climbed to 9th. Niche but critical domains (scientific computing, legacy infra, bioinformatics) will keep demanding these skills.

Concentration Risk: 49% in 4 Languages

Python, C, C++, and Java together account for 48.97% of the index. This concentration means ecosystem shifts in any one of them ripple across the entire industry.